

A FEMALE CRUSOE.

ON AN ISLAND IN THE PACIFIC.

Wild Women Found on the Isolated
Island of San Nicholas, Seven
Miles From the California
Coast.

The ingenious tale of *Robinson Crusoe* by De Foe into the "*H. Adams Cruise*," is rivalled by the following story related and verified for by the *San Francisco Chronicle* as true in every particular. Messrs. George Niblack and Charles Brown, both living, are named by the *Chronicle* as its authority for the appended narrative. In the spring of 1855, the schooner "*Nada*," built at Monterey, was chartered by Lewis T. Barton and Isaac J. Sparks for an otter-hunting expedition from Santa Barbara to the coast of Lower California. The trip proved unsuccessful and the vessel put into port at San Pedro. Seventy miles southwest of San Pedro from Santa Barbara is the small island of San Nicholas, which was then inhabited by Indians.

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THEIR STRANGE TRAIL SYSTEM.

The "Nora" was dispatched by the authorities to rescue them to the mainland. Nineteen men, women and children were taken on board, and as the vessel was preparing to depart, one of the Indian mothers discovered that two of her offspring had been kidnapped and left on the island. She sprang overboard and swam ashore in search of the missing children, one of them three years old and the other an infant unable to walk. The "Nora" for some unexplained reason called within the women and her children and were returned to the island. The place was not again visited until 1867, when George Nisbet, a hunter, stopped there for a few days. He noticed three small circular mounds about a mile apart, the walls four feet high and a small opening on one side. Near these openings was a tripod of drift wood supporting dried seal bladders. He also saw a line print which from its small size and arching centre he judged to be that of a woman. He left the island without seeing anyone. In 1862 Nisbet made a second trip at the request of the Mission Fathers at St. John's Bay to make a careful search for the supposed lost Indians. He discovered a basket and clothing made of dog's skins, ropes of seal sinews, four needles, etc., but before commencing the search a heavy storm compelled him

long the beach, a heavy snow-mountain rose to such a more formidable height.

A WOMAN DISCOVERED.

A third expedition, made to the island in 1853, by Niagara, Charles Brown and four Indians from the House of Burgis Mission, was more successful. On the day after landing, Mr. Brown found the object of their search at a distance, and cautiously approaching it from an opposite direction from the remainder of the party, got quite close to her without being observed. She was in one of her gowns or wind-breaks, clothed in garments made of the skins of the dog, without sleeves, low necked and, as observed when standing up, extended almost to the ankles. She was sitting cross-legged, chewing and sucking with a knife made of a piece of bone once driven into a piece of wood. There was no covering on her head excepting a thick mass of matted hair of a yellowish brown color, due in appearance to the sun and air. The hair was short looking as though the two sides had fallen off. She would occasionally raise her head and shake her eyes, and look toward the other men on a sandy plain near the beach, where she evidently was. The balance of the party were now signalled in order that she might be captured if she attempted to escape.

HOW SHE LOOKED AND TALKED.

To the surprise of all she made no attempt to get away, but greeted each one as they approached with a bow and a smile, and chatted all the time in a dialect of their own tongue, although the Indians accompanying Mr. Nibbey were acquainted with several Indian dialects. She was talking apparently to herself from the time Mr. Brown approached to leaving dinner until she was aware of his presence. The expression of her face was pleasant, her features were regular and her complexion much fairer and her form more symmetrical than that of the Indian women on the main land, and she is believed to have belonged to a different and superior race. By signs and other means of communication, she was made aware that they wanted her to accompany them, and without any apparent hesitation she made ready to follow. In their search for where the unknown lay of smoke, they found a beautiful spring of water issuing from a hole above the beach, under a shelving rock.

CHARACTER OF HER HOUSE.

The cracks or houses in this rock were stuck full of bones, and there were other evidences of an occupation of the hole by the inhabitants of the island. These houses were used for nourishment obtained by cooking; they were dried and roasted many times, showing that occasionally she was not even short

that occasionally she was put upon short rations, but at the time of her discovery appeared to have an abundance, such as it was. She retained all her teeth, but they were worn low, supposed to be due to her chewing tough and solid articles of food. Her age appeared to be about 30 years. Mr. Brown made her a shirt of ticking, with which, and a sailor's cotton shirt and a black necktie, her dress was complete.

—**WAS TAKEN FROM SANTA BARBARA.**

On arriving at Santa Barbara, she was taken to the house of Mr. Nelson, where she became the center of attraction. The Mission Fathers took a great interest in her, sending to Los Angeles and other places, hoping to find some one who could converse with her, but failed. Even the Paganino Indians, who were said to have had an acquaintance with the Indians on the island, could not understand her. Two offers, one of \$1,000, for the privilege of taking her to San Francisco, were refused by Mr. Nelson. When found she was in excellent physical condition, strong and active, but the eating of fruit and vegetable brought on a sickness which, in connection with an injury to the spine received by falling from a perch, terminated her life four weeks later, or seven weeks from the time she landed. Her dress of ding clothes, basket and trinkets were given to Father Mendez of the Mission, who, it is said, sent them to Rome.